

TOO MANY COOKS

How crowded leadership turns work into competition

A story about authority, ambition, and learning to see the system behind the conflict.

Everyone had a reason to feel in charge.

I was managing knowledge and support content inside a customer-experience organization with several managers, team leads, senior specialists, and informal leaders. The reporting lines were visible. The real distribution of power was not.

One ambitious employee had deep frontline credibility and wanted more influence. I held formal accountability. Other leaders controlled parts of the daily workflow. Expertise, trust, access, and process ownership all pulled on the same work.

The result looked interpersonal: decisions reopened, concerns traveled through side conversations, and initiative sometimes crossed into circumvention. I felt my authority being tested. The employee felt blocked. Both interpretations contained truth, but neither explained why the conflict kept returning.

The organization had distributed power without making its boundaries legible.

My first instinct was to win the relationship.

I read the conflict as a referendum on whether I was being respected. That made every disagreement feel larger than the decision in front of us.

I tightened my grip in small ways: more involvement, more reassurance through approval, more attention to whether the process had been followed. The employee responded by leaning harder on expertise, peer trust, and informal influence. Each of us experienced our behavior as a reasonable reaction to the other.

What I could not see clearly yet was the loop:

- The employee felt underused and acted more independently.
 - I experienced that independence as a threat to unsettled authority.
 - I added control.
- The added control confirmed the employee's sense of gatekeeping.

This is the uncomfortable part of the story: my concern about governance was not imaginary, but my reaction sometimes mixed a legitimate boundary with a need to feel secure.

The structure came before the personality.

The more useful question was not, 'Who is the difficult person?' It was: 'What combination of structure, leadership behavior, and individual conduct is producing this pattern - and which parts can I change?'

That question did not excuse anyone. It improved the sequence of diagnosis. Before judging motive, I learned to ask who owned the problem, who could make the decision, whose input was required, what the employee could decide independently, and what happened after disagreement.

A clear org chart can still hide contested authority. If the same question can travel to three leaders and return with three answers, authority has not been distributed. It has been diffused.

Three truths can coexist

- The structure may be enabling the conflict.
- The manager may be reinforcing it.
- The employee may still be choosing unacceptable behavior.

Good leadership holds all three without rushing to find a villain.

Make power visible.

'In charge' is not one thing. Formal authority, operational control, expertise, social influence, access, and process ownership all shape what happens. The goal is not to eliminate those forms of power. It is to connect each one to a boundary and a responsibility.

OWNER	Accountable for the result and the health of the system.
DECIDER	Makes the final call on a defined decision.
CONTRIBUTOR	Provides expertise or affected-party input.
EXECUTOR	Carries out the decision within agreed guardrails.

The failure modes are symmetrical: responsibility without authority creates frustration; authority without accountability creates shadow management.

Give disagreement a route.

Telling people they can disagree is not enough. They also need to know where disagreement belongs, who decides, and what commitment means afterward.

CHALLENGE -> DISCUSS -> DECIDE -> COMMIT -> REVISIT WITH EVIDENCE

This sequence creates room for strong dissent without turning every decision into a permanent campaign. A decision can be reopened when new facts, measurable results, or changed conditions justify it. Persistent dislike is not new evidence.

I also learned to separate private conversation from shadow governance. Venting and sensemaking are normal. The boundary is crossed when a private network begins deciding, distorting information, or exercising authority without responsibility.

Regulate conduct, not loyalty.

Interrupt the loop from three directions.

When tension rises between a manager and an ambitious employee, examine the system, the manager's reaction, and the employee's conduct at the same time.

THE STRUCTURE

Are decision rights clear? Is responsibility matched with useful authority? Are adjacent leaders competing over the same territory?

THE MANAGER

Am I protecting a real governance boundary or defending my status? Would the idea bother me if it arrived calmly and directly?

THE EMPLOYEE

Did they use an available channel? Are they acting beyond delegated scope? Do they represent team opinion honestly and accept decisions they argued against?

Self-reflection should improve diagnosis. It should not become an indefinite substitute for accountability.

Ambition found legitimate territory.

The eventual answer was not to fabricate a management title or suppress influence. The employee developed deeper specialization in warranty work and technical troubleshooting.

Because he understood both frontline customer experience and the warranty function, he could translate between the two in a way few others could. He became a warranty specialist and took over cross-training for the customer-experience team.

His influence grew through expertise, training, and responsibility rather than ambiguous authority over peers. What had contributed to territorial friction became organizational infrastructure.

The lesson was not that every conflict disappears when someone receives more scope. Bounded ownership is also diagnostic: does the person improve the area, invite expertise, finish the work, share credit, and respect the border?

Increase influence, autonomy, and impact without inventing authority over other people.

A clearer leadership sequence.

1. Map the power, not just the titles.

Name who owns, decides, contributes, and executes. Identify where expertise, trust, access, and process control shape the outcome.

2. Make dissent safe and finite.

Invite challenge, hear the strongest case, make the decision, and define what evidence would justify reopening it.

3. Give ambition bounded scope.

Offer meaningful ownership with explicit decisions, constraints, resources, review points, and measures of success.

4. Address behavior without guessing motive.

Describe what happened, its impact, the relevant standard, and a question. If the pattern continues after roles and channels are clear, manage it as accountability.

The order matters: examine the structure, examine my reaction, clarify legitimate scope, then hold the behavioral boundary.

Clarity is not control.

I began with a personal question: how do I make a difficult employee respect my authority? That question kept me focused on winning the relationship.

The better question was: what conditions made the relationship take that shape, and what was still mine to change?

I learned that authority becomes more durable when its borders are visible, not when a manager defends it in every disagreement. Influence becomes more valuable when it carries responsibility. Ambition becomes useful when it has real scope. Dissent becomes safer when it has a route.

This interpretation does not excuse every choice. It gives me a better way to understand conflict and a more confident basis for action.

Authority needs boundaries.

Dissent needs safety.

Ambition needs pathways.

Influence needs responsibility.

That is how I now think about leading when everyone is in charge: make power visible, useful, and accountable before its shadow version takes over.